

Strategy Knotworking

Liberating Structures Slowdown Series | April, May & June 2026

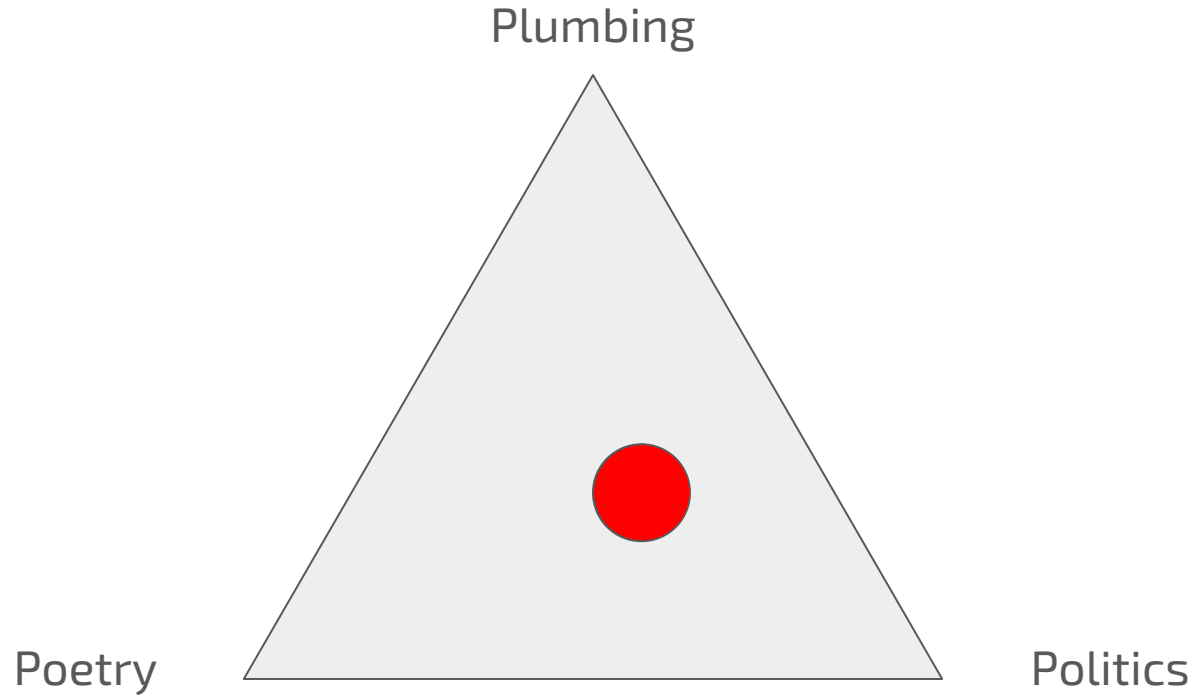
Session III

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Where has your attention needed to be today? Where would you have preferred to spend your time & energy?



*A bow to both James March *On Leadership* and Robert Keidel *Seeing Organizational Patterns**

A true Strategy Knotworking **Slow**down might look like several days, several months, or even several years...

Agenda Sequence

Session 1

Arriving & Settling

Knot By-the-Book (Rapid Writing)

Strategy Knotworking Background

Purpose

Baseline

Context

Conclusion

Session 2

Arriving & Settling

Recap Session 1

Context

Challenge

Ambitions

Conclusion

Session 3

Arriving & Settling

Recap Sessions 1 & 2

Action & Evaluation

Stories and Examples
from Strategy
Knotworking

Conclusion

Finding a Focus

Option 1: A current or upcoming project that you want to generate a strategy for

Option 2: A change or transition you are anticipating

Option 3: If you have a business, practice, organization, or community you are part of and want to elaborate on the strategy for it, you can pick that, too

Narrow in on something tangible.

Strategy Knotworking

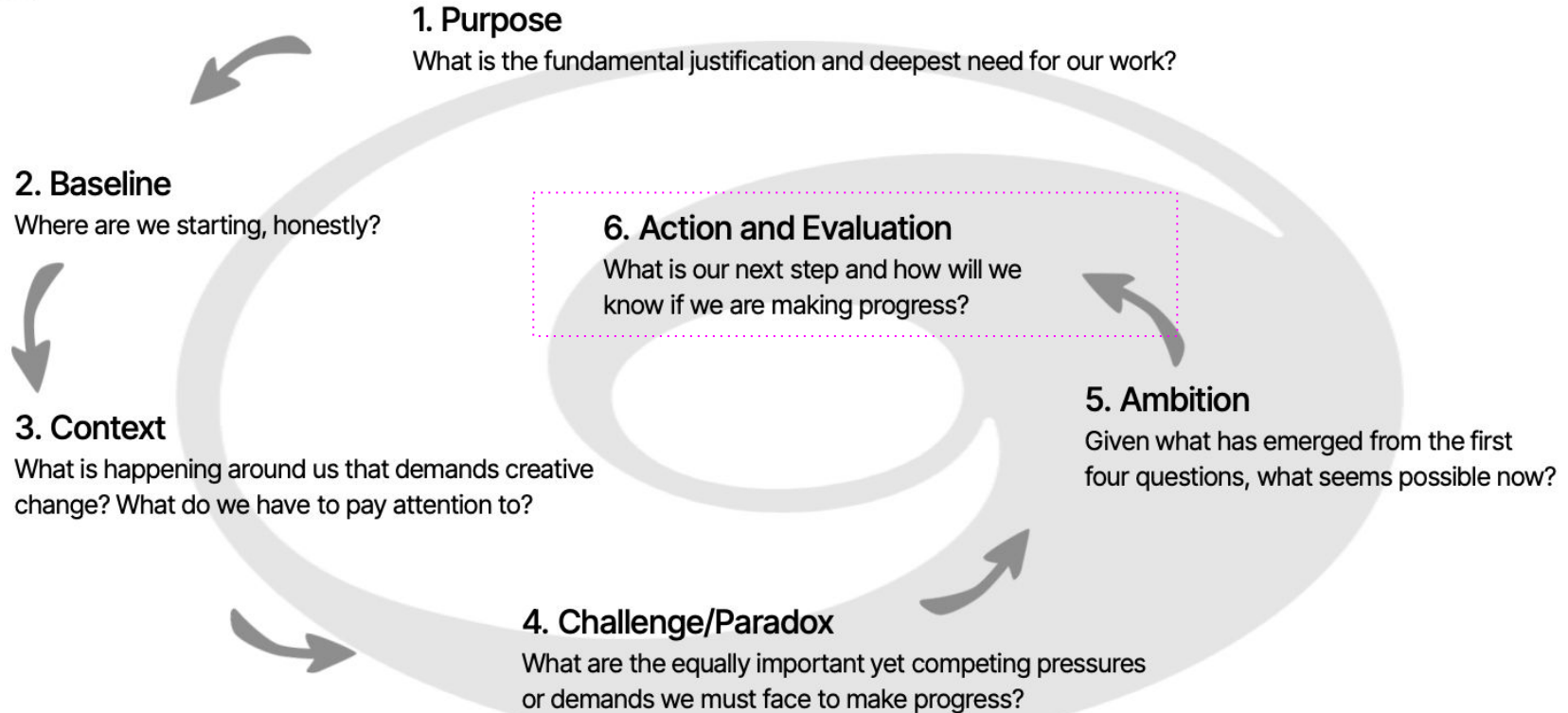
Purpose: Answer Six Questions Together to Develop
Strategy Everyone Owns

Purposes

In Strategy Knotworking (SKW), participants answer six questions to develop a strategic initiative in a complex context. It is designed to engage everyone who will execute the strategy in its development, building shared ownership of higher-order goals and capacity to respond to uncertainty. SKW reinforces the LS principle *Amplify Freedom and Responsibility*.



Strategy Knotworking (SKW) Template



Strategy Knotworking as...

- Umbrella, with LS Nested within
- Ecosystem, Garden, Forest
- Approach for Ongoing Attunement
- Scaffolding for Individual Transitions
- Kaleidoscope

Action & Evaluation

Actions & Evaluation

What are we actually going to spend time & resources on? What principles will guide our choices moving forward? What options can we see? How will we know we are making progress? What are we doing to move deliberately into the future?

How are we cultivating adjacent possibilities/options that will enable us to respond more effectively in the future? How will we evaluate whatever develops? What do we need to stop doing that is no longer delivering value? What operational structures, habits, and practices will support us along the way?

Action & Evaluation Method Options

- 15% Solutions
- 1-2-4-All
- 25/10 Crowdsourcing
- **Minimum Specifications**
- **TRIZ**
- **Kanban & Ecocycle**

Y^n Writing

Purpose: Quickly invite people to generate many options or responses to a question, challenge, or opportunity

*When it comes to my purpose, baseline, context,
challenges, and ambitions, what feels important...*

Ideas that build on what I/ we have already done...

*Ideas that are more of a reach, but worthy of our/
my attention...*

What I personally want to prioritize...

What I believe it is most strategically advantageous to prioritize...

What should come next in our work together...

In pairs or trios, share what comes to mind as you consider taking all your work forward.

Minimum Specifications

Purpose: Specify Only the Absolute “Must dos” and “Must not dos” for Achieving a Purpose

Back Ground

As with many LS, [Minimum Specifications is described in Edgeware](#) by Brenda Zimmerman, Paul Plsek, and Curt Lindberg

Paul in particular took the work around Min Specs further. Here's a [good article](#) where he & Tim Wilson describe attributes of Minimum Specifications, which "typically provide four things that create an environment in which innovative, complex behaviours can emerge: **direction pointing; boundaries; resources; permissions.**"

Kathleen Eisenhardt & Donald Sull also wrote extensively about Simple Rules. Here are two good summaries of their work: [Harvard Business Review article](#) & [Farnham Street blog](#). In addition to Herbert Simon, here are a few attributes or types of Simple Rules: **Boundary, prioritizing, and stopping**—help provide guidelines on what to do—"what is acceptable to do, what is more, important to do, and what to stop doing." There are also **process rules**, which describe how-to do something.

Much of the inspiration for Minimum Specifications comes from computational efforts to model complex behaviors or phenomena in nature - for instance the flocking or murmuration of birds & starlings. [Craig Reynolds developed a computer simulation - Boids - in the late 1980s that achieved this.](#)

Similarly, there are some fun computer programs or simulators that let you play with min specs or are based on simple rules:

- [StarLogo and the Education Arcade at MIT](#)
 - [Here's the original tutorial](#)
- [Conway's Game of Life](#)

Minimum Specifications as...

- Principles, an attitude, aesthetic, or set of commitments
- Simple rules, heuristics, requirements

Minimum Specifications that are meant to...

- Confer the flexibility to pursue new opportunities while maintaining some consistency
- Make it fast and easy for people, organizations, and governments to make sound choices
- Allow the members of a community to synchronize their activities with one another on the fly

Examples of Min Specs

Revisit your Strategy Knotworking narrative.

Begin making a list of everything you MUST DO to advance your purpose, respond to your context, navigate the tensions & challenges, and reach towards your ambitions.

Then, do the same for everything that you MUST NOT DO or avoid at all costs.

Review your list and one-by-one consider each item - if you ignored or neglected it could you still move forward towards your purpose, ambition, or goal?

Scratch out anything that is not essential.

TRIZ

Purpose: Stop Counterproductive Activities and Behaviors
to Make Space for Innovation

Background Notes

Inspired by one small element of the eponymous Russian engineering approach teoriya resheniya izobretatelskikh zadatch

3 Steps of TRIZ

1. Describe the worst result possible (of a project, activity, situation) and then generate a list of everything you could do to guarantee that would happen.
2. Review the list of counter-productive actions and look for how those show up in your current behaviors.
3. Identify the specific things you need to STOP doing and what kind of support or help you need from others if they see you falling off the horse.

Step 1: Given your purpose, baseline, context, challenges, and ambitions, what is the worst result possible? Describe it playfully & evocatively.

Step 2: Start writing down a list of everything you could personally do to guarantee that you got the result just described.

Be creatively-yet-pragmatically devious. How could you sabotage, interfere with, undermine, or otherwise ensure a disappointing outcome?

Step 2.5: In pairs or trios, share your worst result and the list of behaviors.

Invite your partners to help brainstorm additional actions that would make sure that the bleak outcome happens.

Step 3: Alone, review your full list of behaviors and then ask yourself:

"Is there anything on this list that resembles a current behavior or practice of mine?"

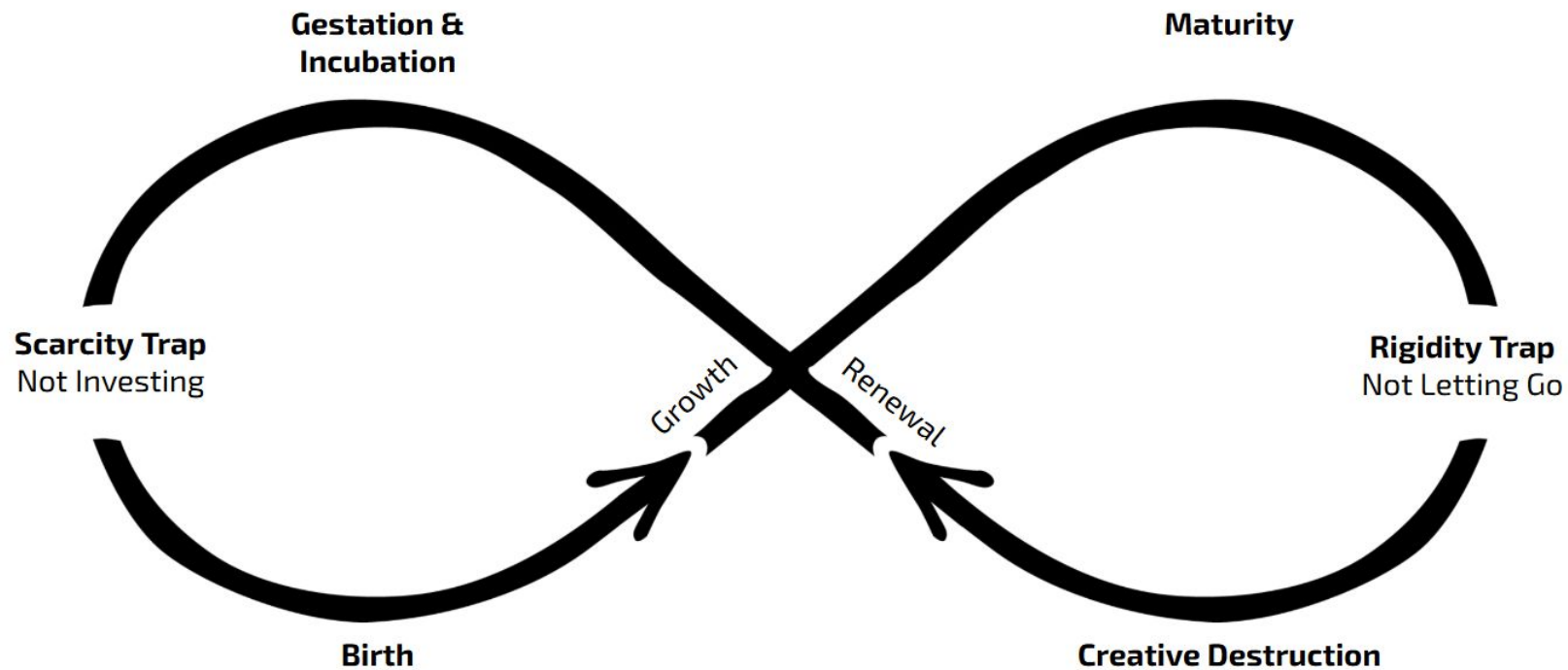
Be generously unforgiving with yourself

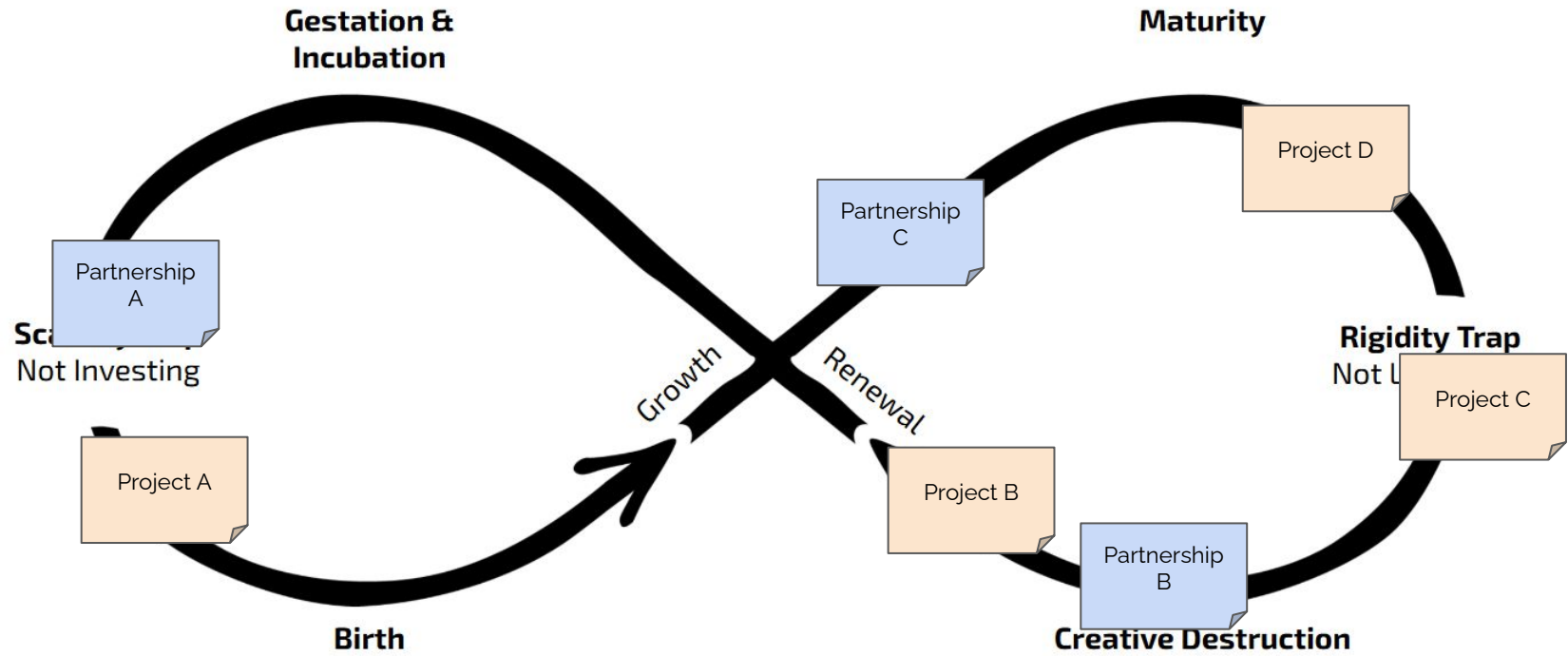
Step 3.5: For any items you've circled, try to identify the causes or reasons that you fall into that counterproductive behavior.

Step 4: Back with your partners, share any of the items you've identified and then together work through how you could STOP engaging in the behavior or practice. What needs to happen for you to knock it off? How could you ask others to help you stop it - try to be specific and tangible here?

Ecocycle Planning

Purpose: Analyze the Full Portfolio of Activities and Relationships to Identify Obstacles and Opportunities for Progress





Past Choices

Do the lit
review

Task/Project
/Activity

Write
Introduction

Task/Project
/Activity

In Progress (1)

Options & Strategies

Must Do

.....

Should Do

.....

Task/Project
/Activity

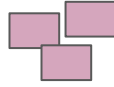
Task/Project
/Activity

Might Do

Past Choices

In Progress

Options & Strategies



Gestation & Incubation

Options & Strategies

In Progress

Past Choices

Maturity

Scarcity Trap
Not Investing

Rigidity Trap
Not Letting Go

Growth

Renewal

Birth

Creative Destruction

Options & Strategies

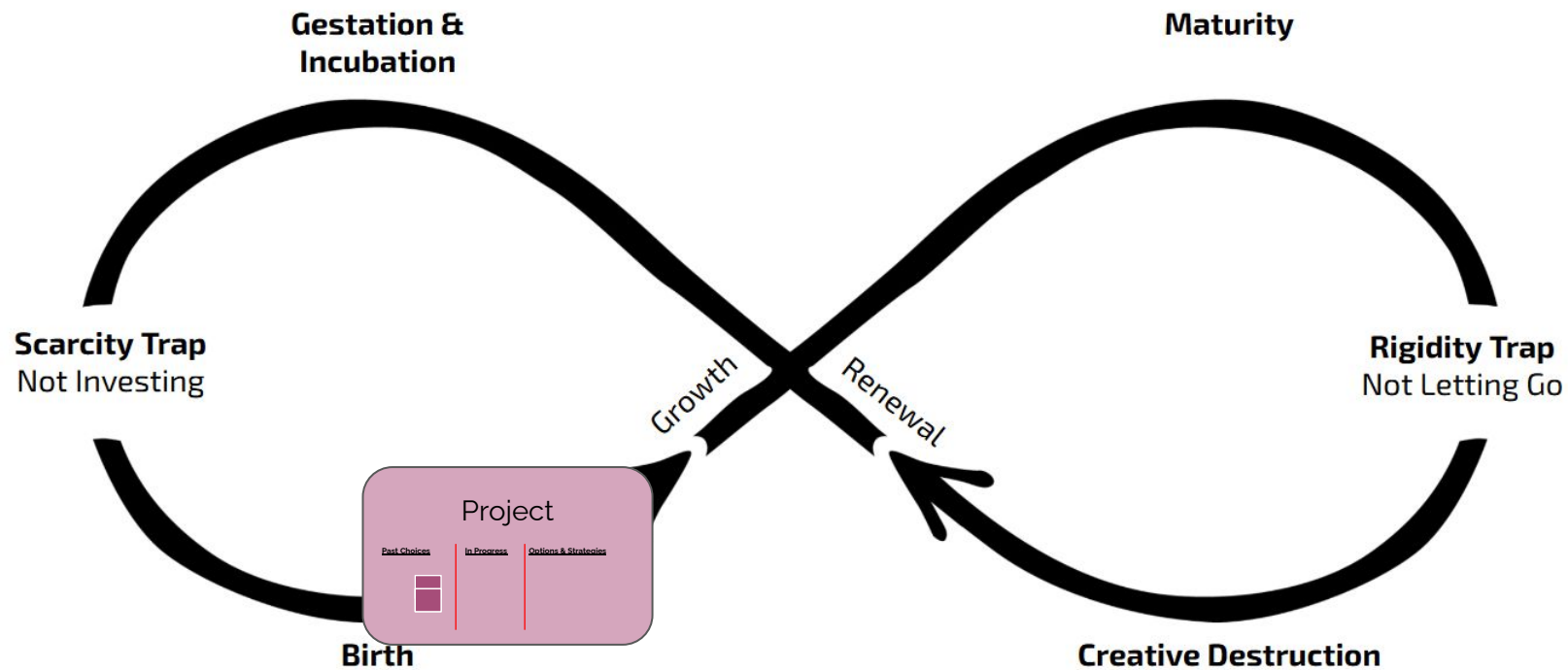
In Progress

Past Choices

Past Choices

In Progress

Options & Strategies



Using Strategy Knotworking

Stories and Examples

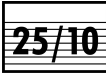
If you have an example or a story to tell, share that you do via chat!

If you have questions, stuck points, annoyance, complaints, curiosities, share that, too!

Stories and Examples

Two ends of a continuum:

- Saginaw Valley State Business School: Involving Everyone in SKW
- Strategy Knotworking During Career Transitions: A Highly Personal SKW

Dimension	Question	Structure
1 Purpose	What is the fundamental purpose and justification for the existence of our work? (Result: Purpose statement)	1-2-4-All, Nine Whys  
2 Context	What is happening around us that demands creative change? (Stop/Start/Change)	Creative Destruction, W3  
3 Challenge	What wicked questions and paradoxical challenges must we face to make progress?	Wicked Questions, Critical Uncertainties  
4 Baseline	Where are we starting, honestly?	Ecocycle 
5 Ambition	Given our purpose, what seems possible now?	1-2-4-All  
6 Action & Evaluation	How are we acting our way toward the future, evaluating what is possible as we go?	15% Solutions, Troika Consulting  

Evaluation Template

